

UPSC Mock Examination — Comprehensive GS Paper (All Subjects)

Date: 14 June 2026 | Maximum Marks: 165 | Time: 3 Hours

Topics: Polity & Governance | Economy | International Relations | Environment | Health & Science | Internal Security | Art & Culture | CA Week June 7–13 2026

INSTRUCTIONS:

- This paper has 4 Sections: Section A (MCQ + CSAT), Section B (10-mark Mains), Section C (20-mark Mains), Section D (Essay).
- Section A: Each MCQ carries +2.00 for correct answer, -0.66 for wrong answer, 0 for unattempted.
- Section B: Answer any 3 questions in approximately 150 words each. Each question carries 10 marks.
- Section C: Answer both questions in approximately 250 words each. Each question carries 20 marks.
- Section D: Attempt ONE essay from the two choices. Essay carries 25 marks (1000–1200 words).
- Answers must be written in the separate Answer Booklet provided. Do NOT write answers on this paper.
- Use of diagrams, flowcharts and maps is encouraged in Mains answers wherever appropriate.
- Mobile phones and electronic devices are strictly prohibited inside the examination hall.

SECTION A — OBJECTIVE (MCQ + CSAT) (70 Marks | +2.00 Correct | -0.66 Wrong | 0 Unattempted)

Read each question carefully. Choose the single best answer from options (A), (B), (C), (D).

■ Part A-1 — Conceptual (Q1–10) | 2 marks each

Questions based on static concepts from the GS syllabus: Delimitation, AFSPA, Collegium, Ramsar, TFR/NRR, Transgender Rights, RBI LAF, Environmental Ethics, Labour Codes, DPI/UIP.

Q1. With reference to the 84th Constitutional Amendment Act (2001) and delimitation of parliamentary constituencies, which of the following is correct?

(A) The 84th Amendment froze the total number of seats allocated to each State in the Lok Sabha based on the 1971 Census, while permitting readjustment of constituency boundaries within States using the 2001 Census — the freeze to remain until the first Census after 2026

(C) Delimitation of Lok Sabha constituencies is conducted by the Election Commission of India under the superintendence of the Supreme Court

(B) Article 82 permanently fixes the total strength of the Lok Sabha at 543 seats; any change requires a constitutional amendment ratified by more than half the States

(D) The 87th Constitutional Amendment (2003) used the 2011 Census as the basis for redrawing parliamentary constituency boundaries in all States

Q2. Which of the following correctly describes the powers and provisions of the Armed Forces (Special Powers) Act, 1958 (AFSPA)?

(A) Under AFSPA Section 3, only the Central Government has the power to declare an area as 'Disturbed Area' — State Governments and Governors have no such power

(C) The Jeevan Reddy Committee (2005) recommended comprehensive amendments to AFSPA — including a sunset clause and accountability provisions — while retaining its core protective immunity for armed forces personnel

(B) Under AFSPA Section 4, a commissioned officer may arrest without warrant, enter premises without warrant, and use force (including lethal force) against a person acting in contravention of any law or order — provided due warning is given

(D) AFSPA 1958 is a single unified statute applicable across all disturbed areas in India, including both Northeast states and Jammu & Kashmir

Q3. The collegium system for appointment of Supreme Court judges emerged through judicial interpretation. Consider the following statements:

1. The 'Second Judges Case' (1993) established that the Chief Justice of India's collegium recommendation for SC appointments is binding on the executive.

2. The 'Third Judges Case' (1998) expanded the collegium composition to the CJI plus the four senior-most Supreme Court judges.

3. The National Judicial Appointments Commission (NJAC) Act 2014 was struck down by the Supreme Court as unconstitutional, holding that it violated the independence of the judiciary — a basic structure element.

Which of the above is/are correct?

(A) 3 only

(C) 1, 2 and 3

(B) 1 only

(D) 1 and 2 only

Q4. With reference to Ramsar Wetlands and India's wetland conservation framework, which of the following is correct?

(A) Ramsar sites in India are exclusively managed by the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change — State Governments have no administrative role over designated Ramsar wetlands

(C) India became a signatory to the Ramsar Convention in 2002, making it one of the later Asian nations to join the international wetland conservation framework

(B) The Ramsar Convention (1971) explicitly excludes artificial waterbodies such as reservoirs, fish ponds and rice paddies from its definition of wetlands

(D) The JPN Bird Sanctuary (Jai Prakash Narayan Bird Sanctuary), designated India's 100th Ramsar site on World Environment Day (June 5, 2026), is located in Ballia district, Uttar Pradesh, and is locally known as Surha Tal

Q5. Which of the following correctly explains demographic concepts central to India's population policy debate?

(A) A Net Reproduction Rate (NRR) of 1 indicates exact replacement — each generation replacing itself — and corresponds to a Total Fertility Rate (TFR) of approximately 2.1 children per woman in most demographic settings

(C) The Demographic Dividend refers exclusively to the economic benefit of a declining birth rate and has no connection to changes in the working-age population share or age-dependency ratio

(B) India's national TFR (2024-25 NFHS data) stands at 2.8, with all southern states still recording TFRs above the replacement level of 2.1

(D) India's National Population Policy 2000 set 2015 as the target year for achieving population stabilisation at replacement-level fertility

Q6. Which of the following is correct with reference to the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Act, 2019?

(A) The Act was a direct legislative implementation of the Supreme Court's NALSA judgment (2014) and fully incorporated the NALSA recommendation for self-identification of gender without any administrative intermediary

(C) The Act mandates a 2% reservation for transgender persons in government employment and central educational institutions — the first group-specific reservation outside the SC/ST/OBC framework

(B) The Act has been widely criticised for requiring transgender persons to obtain a certificate from the District Magistrate to change their legal gender — which critics argue contradicts the self-identification principle upheld in NALSA (2014)

(D) The National Council for Transgender Persons constituted under the Act is chaired by the Union Home Minister as ex-officio Chairperson

Q7. Consider the following statements about the Reserve Bank of India's Liquidity Adjustment Facility (LAF) corridor:

1. The LAF corridor has three rates: Standing Deposit Facility (SDF) at the bottom, Repo Rate in the middle, and Marginal Standing Facility (MSF) at the top.

2. The Repo Rate is the rate at which commercial banks borrow overnight funds from the RBI against eligible government securities as collateral.

3. The Standing Deposit Facility (SDF), introduced in April 2022, allows the RBI to absorb excess liquidity from banks WITHOUT providing collateral — unlike the earlier Reverse Repo which required collateral on the RBI's side.

Which of the above is/are correct?

(A) 1 and 2 only

(C) 1, 2 and 3

(B) 2 and 3 only

(D) 1 only

Q8. Which of the following correctly distinguishes 'Biocentrism' from 'Ecocentrism' in environmental ethics?

(A) Biocentrism holds that the entire ecosystem — including abiotic components like soil, water and climate — has intrinsic moral value, while Ecocentrism restricts moral consideration only to individual sentient animals

(C) Anthropocentrism and Biocentrism are essentially equivalent philosophies — both place human welfare as the ultimate measure of all environmental value

(B) Ecocentrism, as articulated in Aldo Leopold's 'Land Ethic', limits moral consideration exclusively to vertebrate animals capable of experiencing pain and suffering

(D) Biocentrism extends intrinsic moral value to all living organisms including plants and microorganisms, while Ecocentrism extends this further to entire ecosystems including their abiotic components such as soil, water and climate

Q9. India's four Labour Codes (2019-2020) consolidate 29 central labour laws. Which of the following correctly identifies the consolidation structure?

(A) The Code on Wages (2019) consolidates the Minimum Wages Act, Payment of Wages Act, Equal Remuneration Act and Payment of Bonus Act; the Industrial Relations Code consolidates the Industrial Disputes Act, Trade Unions Act and Industrial Employment (Standing Orders) Act

(C) The Occupational Safety, Health and Working Conditions Code applies exclusively to factories employing more than 500 workers, exempting all small enterprises and informal establishments

(B) The Code on Social Security consolidates only the EPF Act and ESI Act, covering only formal sector employees in establishments with 20+ workers

(D) All four Labour Codes were simultaneously operationalised across all States in April 2022, after the Centre notified the Central Rules for all four Codes

Q10. Which of the following correctly describes the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) and the Unified Payments Interface (UPI)?

(A) NPCI is a statutory body established under the Payment and Settlement Systems Act 2007, with the Reserve Bank of India as its sole shareholder and primary regulator for all payment system oversight

(C) UPI functions as India's Central Bank Digital Currency (CBDC), issued directly by the Reserve Bank of India as legal tender for retail and inter-bank digital transactions

(B) NPCI is a not-for-profit company incorporated under Section 8 of the Companies Act, promoted jointly by the RBI and the Indian Banks' Association (IBA), and it operates UPI — which was officially launched on April 11, 2016

(D) India's Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI) framework is limited to UPI alone; the JAM trinity (Jan Dhan-Aadhaar-Mobile) and ONDC are separate government initiatives outside the DPI architecture

■ Part A-2 — Advanced / Application (Q11–20) | 2 marks each

Questions require analytical application of concepts: AFSPA immunity, judicial removal, Indus Waters abeyance, NITI Aayog, Nipah One Health, IRGC/UNCLOS, Labour Code FTE provisions, Delimitation Commission, G-Sec FAR/JPMorgan, Jaitapur CLNDA.

Q11. Which of the following is/are correct about the Armed Forces (Special Powers) Act and relevant Supreme Court pronouncements?

1. Under Section 3 of AFSPA, only the Central Government can declare an area as 'Disturbed Area' — a State Government or Governor cannot exercise this power.
2. The Supreme Court's 2016 judgment in *Extra Judicial Execution Victim Families Association v. Union of India* held that AFSPA does not provide blanket immunity from prosecution for deaths caused by armed forces personnel.
3. The Jeevan Reddy Committee (2005), constituted by the UPA Government, recommended outright repeal of AFSPA and absorption of its essential provisions into other existing central laws.

Which of the above is/are correct?

(A) 1 and 2 only

(B) 1 only

(C) 2 and 3 only

(D) 1, 2 and 3

Q12. Which of the following correctly describes the constitutional process for removal of a Supreme Court judge under Article 124(4)?

(A) A Supreme Court judge can be removed by the President solely on the recommendation of the Chief Justice of India — parliamentary involvement is required only for the Chief Justice's own removal

(B) Under Article 124(4), a judge can be removed by an address passed by either House of Parliament individually by a simple majority — a joint sitting of both Houses is then required for Presidential action

(C) The Judges (Inquiry) Act 1968 provides for investigation by an inquiry committee comprising only retired Supreme Court judges — no High Court Chief Justice or external jurist is included

(D) Under Article 124(4), removal requires an address from EACH House of Parliament — passed by a majority of the total membership of that House AND by not less than two-thirds of members present and voting — before the President can act

Q13. India's decision to put the Indus Waters Treaty (IWT) 'in abeyance' following the Pahalgam terror attack (2025) raises the following legal and strategic considerations:

1. India's legal argument could rest on the Vienna Convention on the Law of Treaties (VCLT) doctrines of 'material breach' and 'fundamental change of circumstances' as grounds for suspension of treaty obligations.
2. Pakistan's position is that the IWT is a permanent bilateral treaty that cannot be suspended unilaterally; Pakistan has previously approached the Permanent Court of Arbitration on IWT disputes.
3. India can immediately divert full western river (Indus, Jhelum, Chenab) flows to Indian agriculture since the engineering infrastructure to do so is already in place.

Which of the above is/are correct?

(A) 1 and 2 only

(B) 1 only

(C) 2 and 3 only

(D) 1, 2 and 3

Q14. Which of the following correctly distinguishes NITI Aayog from the erstwhile Planning Commission?

(A) Unlike the Planning Commission which was a statutory body under the Planning Commission Act 1950, NITI Aayog is established under Article 263 of the Constitution as an Inter-State Council

(B) The Planning Commission had power to allocate central assistance funds to States under the Gadgil Formula, whereas NITI Aayog is an advisory think-tank body established by executive Cabinet Resolution, with no fund-allocation authority

(C) NITI Aayog's Governing Council meetings are constitutionally mandated under Article 275 as the primary mechanism for disbursal of Revenue Deficit Grants to States

(D) NITI Aayog replaced the Planning Commission through the 101st Constitutional Amendment Act 2016, necessitated by the shift to the cooperative federalism model

Q15. Which of the following correctly applies the 'One Health' framework to the context of Nipah virus risk in India?

(A) One Health is a WHO surveillance programme limited to identifying zoonotic pathogens in domestic livestock — wildlife populations and environmental factors fall outside its scope

(B) In the context of Nipah, One Health requires exclusively treating human cases in isolation; the animal reservoir (Pteropus fruit bats) is addressed separately by the Ministry of Agriculture

(C) The One Health framework recognises the interconnection of human, animal and ecosystem health — in Nipah's case, deforestation-driven loss of bat habitats increases human-bat interface and spillover risk, requiring simultaneous surveillance of fruit bats, domestic animals and human sentinel populations

(D) One Health is enshrined as a statutory framework under India's Epidemic Diseases Act 1897 (amended 2020), placing the Ministry of Health as the sole coordinating authority for all zoonotic outbreaks

Q16. With reference to the US-Iran conflict and the Strait of Hormuz (June 2026), consider the following:

1. The United States designated the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) as a Foreign Terrorist Organisation (FTO) in 2019 — the first time the US had designated a recognised state's military force as an FTO.
2. Under UNCLOS Articles 37-38, the Strait of Hormuz is subject to the 'transit passage' regime — this right of passage cannot be suspended even by the bordering states (Iran and Oman).
3. Kharg Island — from which Iran exports approximately 85-95% of its crude oil — is located inside the Persian Gulf, not within the narrow Strait of Hormuz itself.

Which of the above is/are correct?

(A) 1 only

(B) 2 and 3 only

(C) 1 and 3 only

(D) 1, 2 and 3

Q17. Which of the following is/are correctly stated about specific provisions under India's four Labour Codes (2019-2020)?

1. Under the Industrial Relations Code 2020, Fixed-Term Employees are entitled to the same wages as permanent employees in the same role, and are eligible for gratuity on a pro-rata basis after ONE year of continuous service (not the standard five years).
2. Under the Code on Social Security 2020, gig workers and platform workers are classified as 'employees' of the aggregator platform and are fully entitled to EPF and ESIC contributions from the platform company.
3. The Code on Wages 2019 stipulates that allowances paid to a worker shall not exceed 50% of total remuneration — ensuring at least 50% is paid as 'basic wage' for computing statutory deductions and benefits.

Which of the above is/are correct?

- | | |
|------------------|----------------|
| (A) 1 and 3 only | (B) 1, 2 and 3 |
| (C) 2 and 3 only | (D) 1 only |

Q18. Which of the following correctly describes the Delimitation Commission of India and its legal status?

- | | |
|--|---|
| (A) The Delimitation Commission is a permanent constitutional body under Article 82, with the Chief Election Commissioner as its ex-officio Chairperson and State Election Commissioners as full members | (B) The Delimitation Commission is an independent statutory body under the Delimitation Commission Act — its orders have the force of law and cannot be questioned in any court; the Election Commission of India participates as an associate (non-voting) member, not a full member |
| (C) The Supreme Court has the power to review Delimitation Commission orders if they violate the basic structure of the Constitution, making delimitation orders subject to writ jurisdiction | (D) The most recent Delimitation Commission (2020-23) used the 2011 Census as the basis for redrawing parliamentary constituencies in Assam, Arunachal Pradesh, Manipur, Nagaland and Jammu & Kashmir (UT) |

Q19. India's inclusion in JPMorgan's Emerging Market Government Bond Index (GBI-EM) from June 2024 is significant primarily because:

- | | |
|--|--|
| (A) It mandates that foreign portfolio investors hold a minimum of 5% of outstanding Indian G-Secs, ensuring a stable floor for sovereign debt financing and reducing India's dependence on domestic institutional investors | (B) India's G-Secs were included after the government exempted them from all withholding taxes and stamp duties under the FII Ordinance 2026 — provisions that permanently eliminate taxation on all future FPI bond investments |
| (C) Inclusion was preceded by India's Fully Accessible Route (FAR) for G-Secs — which allows unrestricted foreign investment in specified government bonds — driving automatic passive inflows from global funds that track the JPMorgan index | (D) The index inclusion immediately qualifies Indian rupee-denominated G-Secs as reserve assets in the IMF's Special Drawing Rights (SDR) basket alongside USD, EUR, GBP, JPY and CNY |

Q20. A key legal obstacle preventing finalisation of India-France civil nuclear cooperation for the Jaitapur Nuclear Power Plant (NPP) is:

(A) France's non-membership in the Nuclear Suppliers Group (NSG), preventing it from legally exporting nuclear technology to India under the 2008 India-specific NSG waiver

(C) The Maharashtra Coastal Regulation Zone (CRZ) notification prohibiting industrial construction within 5 km of the Ratnagiri coastline, directly placing the Jaitapur site in a legally restricted zone

(B) India's Defence Acquisition Procedure (DAP) 2020 requiring that all equipment for strategic nuclear installations must be sourced under the 'Buy Indian IDDM' category

(D) Section 17(b) of the Civil Liability for Nuclear Damage Act (CLNDA) 2010, which gives the nuclear operator the right of recourse against equipment suppliers in case of an accident — contradicting international norms (Vienna Convention) where liability rests exclusively with the operator

■ **Part A-3 — Current Affairs: Week June 7–13, 2026 (Q21–30) | 2 marks each**

Questions based on major events and developments from the week of 7–13 June 2026 across Polity, Economy, IR, Environment, Internal Security and Health sectors.

Q21. At the 11th Governing Council meeting of NITI Aayog (June 11, 2026), which of the following was NOT among the key demands raised by State Chief Ministers?

(A) Himachal Pradesh demanded restoration of the Revenue Deficit Grant (RDG), settlement of BBMB arrears of ₹7,000 crore, and ₹90,000 crore compensation for ecological services rendered by hill states

(C) Punjab demanded Special Category Status (SCS), a 90:10 Centre-State funding ratio for centrally sponsored schemes, and recognition of its 553-km Pakistan border security burden

(B) The Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister demanded a national protocol for recognising and monetising gig workers' contributions under the new Labour Codes framework

(D) Multiple Chief Ministers raised the need to revisit the Gadgil Formula framework, noting that the 14th Finance Commission abolished the Special Category Status along with increasing tax devolution to 42%

Q22. The Supreme Court's June 2026 ruling on Motor Accident Compensation for homemakers is correctly described as:

(A) Superseding the Sarla Verma (2009) multiplier method for calculating compensation in fatal accident claims involving homemakers

(C) Designating 'Loss of Domestic Care' as the sixth distinct head of MACT compensation — fixing notional monthly income of a homemaker at ₹30,000, with mandatory 10% upward revision every three years — superseding the earlier Pranay Sethi (2017) guidelines

(B) Delivered under the Court's Article 142 powers, making it binding only on High Courts — Motor Accident Claims Tribunals must await individual High Court implementation orders

(D) Directing all pending MACT cases involving homemaker victims to be suo motu reheard with retrospective application of the ₹30,000 standard from the date of each accident

Q23. Andhra Pradesh's Population Management Policy 2026 is notable primarily because:

(A) It introduces a 'two-child norm' that disqualifies individuals with more than two children from contesting panchayat elections — similar to Rajasthan's 2001 Panchayati Raj amendment

(C) It introduces a tax surcharge on childless urban families to incentivise higher birth rates in demographically declining districts of the state

(B) It proposes increasing women's reservation in government employment from 33% to 50% in districts where TFR has dropped below 1.5

(D) It offers a cash incentive of ₹25,000 for families having a second or third child — recognising that Andhra Pradesh's TFR of approximately 1.3–1.5 is now well below replacement level, posing long-term economic and demographic risks

Q24. With reference to the progressive withdrawal of AFSPA from Northeast India and the June 2026 Assam-Nagaland-Centre tripartite MoU, which of the following is correct?

(A) By 2026, approximately 12 peace accords had been signed between the Centre and Northeast militant groups since 2019, corresponding to an ~80% decline in violence; Manipur and parts of Nagaland remain among the last areas under active AFSPA; the MoU restores oil and mineral exploration in the ~150-km Disputed Area Belt with 50:50 revenue sharing between Assam and Nagaland

(C) The Assam-Nagaland Disputed Area Belt (DAB) falls entirely within Nagaland's administrative jurisdiction under a Supreme Court order of 1988, with Assam retaining only oil revenue rights

(B) AFSPA 1958 and AFSPA 1990 are the same unified statute applicable across all disturbed areas in India — there is no separate Act for Jammu & Kashmir; the distinction is only administrative

(D) Under AFSPA Section 6, prosecution of an army officer for actions taken under the Act requires sanction from the State Government of the state in which the operation took place

Q25. With reference to the Nipah virus outbreak in Kozhikode (June 2026), which of the following is correct?

(A) The Nipah virus was first identified in India during the 2001 Siliguri outbreak (66 deaths), making India the site of the global discovery of the Nipah pathogen

(C) Nipah's global case fatality rate of 40-75% combined with its high basic reproduction number (R_0) of approximately 5-6 makes it more transmissible than SARS-CoV-2, placing it in the top tier of pandemic potential pathogens

(B) The index patient in the June 2026 Kozhikode outbreak was a 43-year-old man from Ramanattukara with suspected exposure to fruit bats in a godown; among the 77 contacts traced, 58 were healthcare workers, 14 were family members and 5 were co-workers

(D) The experimental monoclonal antibody m102.4 used in Nipah treatment received full WHO approval in 2023 and is now part of India's National Stockpile for viral haemorrhagic fever emergency responses

Q26. Consider the following statements about India's TFR decline, the 84th and 87th Constitutional Amendments, and the forthcoming delimitation:

1. The 84th Constitutional Amendment froze the total number of Lok Sabha seats allocated to each State — using 1971 Census figures — until the first Census after 2026, while permitting readjustment of constituency boundaries using the 2001 Census.
2. The 87th Constitutional Amendment (2003) subsequently substituted '1991 Census' with '2001 Census' for the purpose of delimiting constituencies within States (without changing seat allocations).
3. India's national TFR has now fallen to approximately 1.9 — below the replacement rate of 2.1 — while southern states like Andhra Pradesh record TFRs as low as 1.3.

Which of the above is/are correct?

(A) 1 and 2 only

(B) 2 and 3 only

(C) 1, 2 and 3

(D) 3 only

Q27. The Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Amendment Bill 2026 introduced in Parliament primarily addresses which of the following?

(A) It introduces a 2% reservation for transgender persons in government employment and central educational institutions — a demand from the NALSA judgment (2014) that was explicitly excluded from the 2019 Act

(B) It replaces the District Magistrate certificate requirement with a full self-identification model as recommended by the Supreme Court in NALSA (2014) and affirmed in Navtej Singh Johar (2018)

(C) It creates a National Transgender Rights Commission as a statutory body with quasi-judicial powers to adjudicate discrimination complaints and impose financial penalties on violators

(D) It proposes stricter penal provisions and enhanced punishments for offences against transgender persons — addressing the criticism that the 2019 Act's punishment clauses were weaker than protections available under general criminal law

Q28. In *R. Iyyappan v. Union of India* (2026 INSC 431), the Supreme Court quashed the ISRO Gang Labour Scheme 2012 primarily on the ground that:

(A) The scheme violated the 'State as model employer' doctrine — the State cannot perpetuate casual or contract labour arrangements for work of a perennial nature — and contravened Articles 14 and 21 read with the Contract Labour (Regulation and Abolition) Act 1970; the Court distinguished the case from *Umadevi* (2006) which prohibited backdoor regularisation of casual workers

(B) ISRO, as a strategic space agency, is categorically exempt from the CLRA 1970 framework, making the Gang Labour Scheme legally ultra vires from its inception in 2012

(C) The scheme violated Article 21 by denying Gang Labour workers access to Official Secrets Act protections available to direct ISRO scientific staff working at sensitive launch facilities

(D) India's non-ratification of ILO Convention C94 (Labour Clauses in Public Contracts) deprived the ISRO Gang Labour Scheme of its only legitimate legal basis under international labour law

Q29. The Supreme Court (Number of Judges) Amendment Ordinance 2026, promulgated under Article 123, is correctly described as:

(A) Increasing the total strength of the Supreme Court from 31 to 34 judges (including the Chief Justice), specifically to address the backlog of over 80,000 pending constitutional matters

(C) Mandating that the 4 additional judges be exclusively assigned to a new Constitutional Bench division to hear only Article 32 writ petitions and original constitutional interpretation cases

(B) Increasing the authorised strength of the Supreme Court from 34 to 38 judges (including the Chief Justice of India) — exercised under Article 123 to amend the Supreme Court (Number of Judges) Act 1956 while Parliament was not in session

(D) Requiring the collegium to forward recommendations for all 4 new judges within 30 days — failing which the appointments would be made by a committee of the PM, CJI and Leader of Opposition

Q30. Which of the following correctly describes the current status of India-France defence and civil nuclear cooperation (June 2026)?

(A) India and France established a 'Strategic Partnership' in 1998 — India's first with any country — and the proposed 114-jet Rafale deal (2026) is the single largest defence contract in Indian history by value under the 1998 framework

(C) The India-France bilateral relationship was upgraded to a 'Special Global Strategic Partnership' (SGSP) in 2023; a primary obstacle for the Jaitapur NPP remains CLNDA 2010 Section 17(b) — the operator-to-supplier liability recourse clause that French equipment suppliers refuse to accept

(B) PM Modi's June 2026 France visit culminated in the signing of the Jaitapur Nuclear Power Plant construction contract, which had been pending since 2008 — with all contractual and liability disputes finally resolved

(D) The 114-jet Rafale deal (2026) covers exclusively Rafale-Marine naval aircraft for INS Vikrant and INS Vikramaditya — replacing the carrier-based MiG-29K fleet with no Indian Air Force component

■ Part A-4 — CSAT: Reading Comprehension, Data Interpretation & Logical Reasoning (Q31–35) | 2 marks each

Questions test reading comprehension, data interpretation and analytical reasoning. No specialised domain knowledge is required — all information needed is provided.

Q31. Read the following passage and answer the question below. "The collegium system for judicial appointments in India emerged entirely through judicial interpretation in the Second and Third Judges Cases (1993 and 1998). The collegium — comprising the Chief Justice of India and the four senior-most Supreme Court judges — makes recommendations for appointments and transfers that are binding on the executive. Critics argue that this system lacks transparency, democratic accountability and diversity in representation. Supporters contend that judicial independence from executive interference is a constitutional imperative — particularly necessary in a polity where separation of powers is foundational." Based solely on the passage, which of the following inferences can be MOST directly and accurately drawn?

(A) The collegium system is constitutionally superior to the executive-led appointment model that the NJAC Act 2014 attempted to introduce

(C) The collegium system was established by Parliamentary legislation after extensive post-Emergency debates on the independence of the judiciary

(B) All five collegium members must be unanimous before any judicial appointment recommendation is forwarded to the President for assent

(D) The collegium system is a judicial interpretation of constitutional provisions rather than a legislative enactment, and its legitimacy is contested on the grounds of transparency and democratic accountability

Q32. Consider the following statements about Nipah outbreaks in Kerala: P: Kerala's first Nipah outbreak occurred in 2018; subsequent outbreaks occurred in 2021, 2023 and 2026. Q: In each successive outbreak, the number of contacts traced by health authorities has been larger than in the preceding outbreak. R: Kerala's case fatality rate in Nipah outbreaks (approximately 30-45%) is lower than the global average (40-75%). If all three statements are accepted as true, which of the following conclusions can be DEFINITELY drawn?

(A) Kerala has progressively improved its epidemic contact-tracing capacity since 2018, as evidenced by the increasing number of contacts identified in successive outbreaks

(C) Kerala's lower case fatality rate compared to the global average proves that the Nipah strain in India is genetically less virulent than the original Malaysia or Bangladesh strains

(B) The increasing number of contacts traced confirms that Nipah virus in Kerala is becoming progressively more transmissible with each successive outbreak

(D) The four Kerala outbreaks combined account for more than 50% of all global Nipah virus cases since the pathogen was first identified in 1999

Q33. The table below shows the Total Fertility Rate (TFR) of selected Indian states and the national average (2024-25). Based solely on this data, which of the following conclusions is CORRECT?

State / Category	TFR (2024-25)
Bihar	3.0
Uttar Pradesh	2.7
Rajasthan	2.4
National Average	1.9
Karnataka	1.7
Kerala	1.5
Tamil Nadu	1.4
Andhra Pradesh	1.3

(A) All four southern states in the table have achieved population stabilisation since their TFR equals the Net Reproduction Rate (NRR) of 1.0

(B) Bihar, Uttar Pradesh and Rajasthan all have TFRs above India's national average of 1.9, while all four southern states shown (Karnataka, Kerala, Tamil Nadu and Andhra Pradesh) have TFRs below the replacement rate of 2.1

(C) The TFR ratio between Bihar (3.0) and Andhra Pradesh (1.3) implies that Bihar's population will grow exactly 2.3 times faster than Andhra Pradesh's population over the next generation

(D) India's national average TFR of 1.9 indicates that India's total population will immediately begin declining in absolute numbers, similar to Japan and South Korea

Q34. The Supreme Court (Number of Judges) Amendment Ordinance 2026 increases the sanctioned strength of the Supreme Court from 34 to 38 judges. If the Court currently has 32 sitting judges (including the CJI) and the average pendency per judge is 2,500 cases, what will be the revised average pendency per judge once all 38 posts are filled — assuming total case pendency remains constant?

(A) 2,200 cases per judge

(B) 2,000 cases per judge

(C) 2,105 cases per judge (approximately)

(D) 1,800 cases per judge

Q35. Read the following passage and answer the question below. "India's Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI) stack — comprising Aadhaar for identity, UPI for payments and DigiLocker for document verification — has emerged as a template for digital development strategies in the Global South. The India Stack has been studied or adopted by over 50 countries. UPI's cross-border integration with Bhutan, Nepal, Singapore and several Gulf nations represents not merely financial connectivity but a new form of 'tech diplomacy' — extending India's soft power through digital infrastructure rather than conventional development assistance." Which of the following is an inference that CANNOT be drawn from the passage alone?

(A) India's DPI stack serves as a replicable model for digitisation strategies of developing and emerging economies

(B) UPI's cross-border integration functions as an instrument of India's soft power and digital diplomacy

(C) The India Stack includes at minimum three components: a digital identity layer, a payment interface and a document management facility

(D) India's DPI model is more inclusive, cost-effective and transparent than China's private-sector digital payment infrastructure (Alipay/WeChat Pay)

SECTION B — MAINS SHORT ANSWER (30 Marks | Attempt any 3 questions | 10 Marks each | 150 words each)

Attempt any THREE questions from this section. Each answer must be within 150 words. Use the directive word as your analytical anchor. Provide a structured response with introduction, analysis, relevant examples and a brief conclusion.

- Q3** **Examine** the 'State as model employer' doctrine as interpreted by the Supreme Court in *R. Iyyappan v. Union of India* (2026 INSC 431). What are its implications for the use of contractual and casual labour in government and public sector organisations?

GS-2 | Polity | Social Justice | 10 Marks | Answer in 150 words

- Q3** **Critically analyse** the gaps in the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Act 2019 in light of the principles established in the *NALSA* judgment (2014) and *Navtej Singh Johar* (2018). How adequately does the proposed 2026 Amendment address these gaps?

GS-2 | Rights of Vulnerable Sections | Social Justice | 10 Marks | Answer in 150 words

- Q3** **Discuss** the significance of the progressive withdrawal of AFSPA from Northeast India since 2019. What conditions are necessary for complete security normalisation in the region, and what does the continuing Kuki-Naga conflict in Manipur indicate about the fragility of peace processes in the Northeast?

GS-3 | Internal Security | Northeast | 10 Marks | Answer in 150 words

- Q3** **Analyse** the tension between India's demographic transition — with TFR below replacement in southern states versus above-replacement TFR in northern states — and the forthcoming delimitation of Lok Sabha constituencies. How can India balance demographic equity with federal political representation?

GS-2 | Polity | Federalism | Demography | 10 Marks | Answer in 150 words

SECTION C — MAINS LONG ANSWER (40 Marks | Both questions compulsory | 20 Marks each | 250 words each)

Both questions in this section are compulsory. Each answer must be within 250 words. Higher marks are awarded for multi-dimensional analysis, use of relevant contemporary examples and a well-structured argument addressing multiple GS angles.

- Q4** The US-Iran conflict over the Strait of Hormuz (June 2026) has exposed structural vulnerabilities in India's energy security, maritime trade and diaspora protection architecture. **Critically analyse** India's strategic dilemmas arising from this crisis — including the 'flag of convenience' problem for Indian seafarers, the balance between energy security and strategic partnerships, and India's options to reduce dependence on Gulf energy chokepoints.

GS-2/GS-3 | International Relations | Energy Security | Maritime Security | 20 Marks | Answer in 250 words

- Q4** 'One Health is not merely a public health concept but a whole-of-government governance framework that demands inter-ministerial coordination, investment in surveillance infrastructure and community behavioural change.' **Critically examine** India's preparedness for zoonotic disease outbreaks such as Nipah, drawing lessons from Kerala's outbreak response model (2018-2026), and identify the structural reforms needed in India's health security architecture to institutionalise the One Health approach.

GS-2/GS-3 | Health Governance | One Health | Zoonotic Diseases | 20 Marks | Answer in 250 words

SECTION D — ESSAY (25 Marks | Attempt ONE essay from the two choices | 1000–1200 words)

Attempt ONE essay from the two choices below. Your essay will be evaluated on: Depth of analysis, Coherence of argument, Relevant examples (contemporary + historical), Philosophical or ethical dimension (where applicable), and Quality of written expression. A well-structured essay with a clear thesis, developed body paragraphs and a reflective conclusion is expected. Length: 1000–1200 words.

- Q4** **Essay Choice 1:** 'The judiciary as democracy's last sentinel — examining the tension between judicial independence and judicial accountability in India's constitutional framework.'

GS-2 Essay | Polity & Governance | Judiciary | 25 Marks | 1000-1200 words

- Q4** **Essay Choice 2:** 'Labour without dignity is development without justice — evaluating India's new Labour Codes through the prism of worker rights, social security and the promise of inclusive growth.'

GS-3/GS-4 Essay | Economy | Labour | Social Justice | 25 Marks | 1000-1200 words

— END OF QUESTION PAPER —

Total: 165 Marks | UPSC Practice Paper | Copilot CLI UPSC Agent